

FOR COUPLES TRYING TO CONCEIVE

# Protect Your *Connection*

RELATIONSHIP GUIDE

Simple tools to stay close, keep intimacy alive, and face the ups and downs of trying, together.

Talk  Touch  Team

FOR BOTH OF YOU

# The part of trying no one *warns* you about

Deciding to have a baby is one of the most exciting choices a couple can make. But trying can quietly put pressure on even the strongest relationship. If that's happening to you, nothing is wrong with you. It's one of the most common experiences couples share, and there's a lot you can do about it.

## What often changes

### Sex gets scheduled

What used to be spontaneous starts to feel like a task with a deadline.

### Moods follow the calendar

Hope before test day, disappointment after. Every month, again.

### You cope differently

One of you wants to talk. The other goes quiet or tries to fix it.

## How to use this guide

- ◯ **Read it together**
  Or each read it on your own, then talk about what stood out.
- ◯ **Take one part a week**
  There are five parts. Small, steady steps work better than a weekend overhaul.
- ◯ **Try the exercises**
  Reading helps, but doing them together is what actually changes things.
- ◯ **Come back when it gets hard**
  Keep this guide handy for tough months. That's when it helps most.

YOUR GUIDE AT A GLANCE

# Five parts, one *strong* team

Each part covers one pressure point and gives you simple tools to handle it together.

PART 1

## Talk to each other

A weekly check-in, a shared plan, and how to bring up hard things gently.

PART 2

## Keep intimacy alive

How to stop sex from turning into a chore, plus small rituals that keep you close.

PART 3

## Ride the monthly rollercoaster

The two-week wait, negative tests, and different ways of coping.

PART 4

## Argue without hurting

Breaks, repair phrases, and how to talk after a hard fight.

PART 5

## Protect your bubble

Boundaries with family and friends, and what to do if it's taking longer.

# The weekly *check-in*

One of the most useful habits for couples who are trying: a short, regular conversation about how it's going. Giving baby talk a set time keeps it from taking over every evening.

## How it works

- **Once a week, 20–30 minutes**
  Same day and time, like Sunday after breakfast.
- **Phones away**
  Give each other your full attention.
- **Take turns**
  One talks, the other listens. Then switch.
- **Listen to understand, not to fix**
  Solutions can wait. Feeling heard comes first.
- **Keep the rest of the week lighter**
  Save the big talks for check-in time.

## Questions for each of you

QUESTION 1

**How are you feeling about trying this week?**

QUESTION 2

**What was hardest for you?**

QUESTION 3

**What helped, even a little?**

QUESTION 4

**What do you need from me this week?**

TO FINISH

**One thing I appreciated about you this week is...**

## What if one of us doesn't like talking?

Keep it short, try it on a walk or a drive, and let the quieter partner go second. Side by side often feels easier than face to face.

## Try it this week

Set a reminder on both phones for your first check-in. After three weeks, it starts to feel natural.

# Say hard things *gently*

How a conversation starts usually decides how it ends. Starting with blame puts your partner on the defensive. Starting with your own feelings and a clear request makes it much easier to hear you.

**I feel ___ about ___. I need ___.**

INSTEAD OF
"You don't even care if we get pregnant."

TRY
"I feel lonely being the only one tracking my cycle. I'd love for us to look at the calendar together each week."

INSTEAD OF
"You turn everything into a science project."

TRY
"I feel pressure when every talk is about ovulation. Can we have one evening this week that's just about us?"

INSTEAD OF
"Why can't you just relax?"

TRY
"I get worried when you seem so stressed about testing. Can we plan test day together?"

INSTEAD OF
"You never want to have sex anymore."

TRY
"I miss feeling close to you. Could we plan a night that has nothing to do with the calendar?"

## When it's your turn to listen

- Don't jump to solutions yet
- Validate: "It makes sense you'd feel that way."
- Say back what you heard in your own words
- Ask: "Is there more?"

Validating isn't the same as agreeing. It just shows you understand.

# Agree on your *shared* plan

Many arguments while trying come from expectations you never said out loud. Talking through these questions early saves a lot of hurt later. You don't need perfect answers, just shared ones.

- ◯ **How much tracking feels okay to each of us?**
  Apps, ovulation tests, temperature: some people find it reassuring, others find it stressful.
- ◯ **Who do we tell that we're trying?**
  Everyone, a few close people, or no one for now?
- ◯ **How do we want to handle test day?**
  Together or alone? Morning or evening? What do we do right after?
- ◯ **When will we see a doctor if it takes a while?**
  Agree on a timeline now, while things feel calm.
- ◯ **How far would we go with fertility treatment?**
  And what budget feels right? It's okay if the answer is “we don't know yet.”
- ◯ **What would make each of us feel supported?**
  Be specific: a hug, space, a walk, taking over dinner.
- ◯ **What's off-limits to say?**
  Some phrases sting more than we realize. Name them.

**Revisit your plan every few months.** Feelings change as time goes on, and that's normal. Your plan can change too.

# When sex starts to feel like a *schedule*

Studies of couples trying to conceive show that timed sex often lowers desire and satisfaction for both partners. It doesn't have to. A few small changes can bring the fun back.

- ◯ **Keep sex for fun on other days too**
  Intimacy outside the fertile window reminds you both it's not only about a baby.
- ◯ **Drop the announcements**
  Swap “I'm ovulating, it's time” for a playful signal or code word you agree on.
- ◯ **Leave the goal out of the bedroom**
  No talk of tests, cycles, or timing during sex.
- ◯ **Don't panic about a missed day**
  Every 1–2 days in the fertile window is plenty. One missed night doesn't ruin the month.
- ◯ **Talk about pressure openly**
  Erection trouble and low desire are common when sex is on a schedule, and they usually pass.
- ◯ **Keep touching outside the bedroom**
  Hugs, holding hands, a real kiss hello and goodbye.

## During the fertile window

Keep it relaxed and playful. Change the setting, take the pressure off, and remember: you're on the same side.

## The rest of the month

Baby-free intimacy. No calendars, no goals. Just the two of you, the way it was before.

# Small rituals, *big* connection

Closeness is built in small moments far more than in grand gestures. Pick two or three of these and make them yours.

### Baby-free date night

Once a week. One rule: no talk about trying.

### End-of-day debrief

Five minutes to share the best and hardest part of your day.

### A real kiss

Not a peck on the way out. A kiss that lasts a few seconds.

### Daily thank-you

Say one specific thing you appreciate about each other.

### Something to look forward to

A trip, a class, a concert. Plans that aren't about a baby.

### Try something new

New experiences together spark the feeling of early dating.

## Questions to reconnect

ASK ME

**What did you love most about us before we started trying?**

ASK ME

**What's one dream for us that isn't about a baby?**

ASK ME

**When did you feel most loved by me lately?**

ASK ME

**What excites you most about becoming a parent?**

ASK ME

**What worries you that you haven't said out loud?**

ASK ME

**What would a perfect weekend look like right now?**

# Getting through the *two-week wait*

The days between ovulation and test day can feel endless. Every twinge becomes a sign. A simple plan makes the wait easier for both of you.

- ◯ **Agree on test day**
  Testing on the day your period is due gives the most reliable result. Decide together if you'll test side by side.
- ◯ **Plan something good for that day**
  Whatever the result, you'll have something to look forward to.
- ◯ **Limit symptom searching**
  Early pregnancy and PMS feel almost the same. Googling rarely helps.
- ◯ **Fill the wait with things you enjoy**
  Movies, walks, friends, projects. Keep life bigger than the calendar.

## If the test is negative

**WHAT HELPS**
"I'm so sorry. I'm here." A hug. Sitting together in the disappointment without rushing it.

**WHAT HURTS**
"Just relax and it'll happen." "At least trying is fun." "Next month for sure."

**WHAT HELPS**
Asking "Do you want to talk, or just be together?" and respecting the answer.

**WHAT HURTS**
Jumping straight into plans and fixes before feelings have had room.



### A few words for test day

Before you look at the result, say it out loud to each other: "Whatever it says, we're in this together." It sounds simple, and it helps.

# You may cope *differently*

Many couples find one partner wants to talk it through while the other goes quiet, gets busy, or tries to solve it. Neither way is wrong. Trouble starts when each of you reads the other's style as not caring.

## The talker

Needs to share feelings to feel better.

- Feels lonely when the other goes quiet
- Is helped most by being heard
- May read silence as “you don't care”

## The processor

Needs space or action to feel better.

- Feels overwhelmed by long talks
- Is helped most by time, movement, or a task
- May read talking as “making it worse”

- ◯ **Name your styles to each other**
  Just saying “I'm a talker, you're a processor” takes a lot of blame out of it.
- ◯ **Meet in the middle**
  Twenty focused minutes of listening for the talker, then real space for the processor.
- ◯ **Remember you're both grieving**
  Partners who seem calm often feel they have to be the strong one. Ask how they're really doing.

**When to get extra support:** if either of you has felt down or hopeless for more than two weeks, or trying is all you talk about, a counselor who specializes in fertility can help a lot.

# Take a break, then *repair*

Stress makes small disagreements blow up fast. When your heart is racing and your thoughts are spinning, no good conversation can happen. That's the moment to pause, not push through.

## How to take a good break

- **Notice the signs**
  Racing heart, feeling hot, shallow breathing, wanting to shout or shut down.
- **Call it with a word or signal**
  Agree on it in advance, like “time-out” or a hand signal.
- **Say when you'll be back**
  At least 20–30 minutes, and no longer than a day.
- **Calm down, don't replay**
  Walk, breathe, read. Rehearsing the fight keeps you upset.
- **Come back and try again**
  Start gently, with the formula from Part 1.

## Repair phrases: pick three

- **Let me try that again, more gently.**
- **I think we're both scared right now.**
- **This is our problem, not yours.**
- **Can you say that more softly?**
- **You're right about part of this.**
- **I'm getting overwhelmed. Can we pause?**
- **What do you need from me right now?**
- **I love you, even when we disagree.**

## If your partner calls a break

Stop talking right away, even mid-sentence. Don't chase them or get the last word. Trust that they'll come back.

## Practice your three phrases

Say them out loud once when you're calm. It makes them much easier to reach for in the heat of the moment.

# Talking it through *after* a hard fight

Once you've both calmed down, a short structured talk helps you understand what went wrong without starting round two. The goal isn't to decide who was right. It's to understand each other.

1. **Share your feelings**
   Each of you names how you felt during the fight: hurt, lonely, scared, unheard. No debating.
2. **Describe what you each saw**
   Take turns telling your side while the other listens and sums it up. Two views can both be true.
3. **Find the sore spot**
   What old worry did it touch? For many couples trying, it's fear of it never happening, or of being blamed.
4. **Own your part**
   What set you up? Tired, stressed, another negative test. Then apologize for your part only.
5. **Make one small plan**
   One thing each of you will do differently next time.

### Wait until calm

Hours or even a day later is fine.

### One fight at a time

Don't pile on old arguments.

### Apologize last

It lands better after you feel understood.

## Common sore spots while trying

- Fear it will never happen
- Feeling blamed
- Feeling alone in it
- Feeling like my body is failing
- Pressure to perform
- Worry about age and time
- Feeling unseen

# Boundaries with *family and friends*

People usually mean well. But questions and advice can sting, especially after a hard month. Decide together how much you share, and have your answers ready.

## Ready-made answers

**THEY ASK**
"So when are you two having a baby?"

**YOU SAY**
"You'll be the first to know when there's news!"

**THEY ASK**
"Have you tried just relaxing?"

**YOU SAY**
"Thanks for caring. We've got it covered."

**THEY ASK**
"Any news yet?"

**YOU SAY**
"Nothing to share right now. How are you doing?"

**THEY SAY**
"My friend got pregnant right after she stopped trying!"

**YOU SAY**
"That's great for her. We're doing what's right for us."

- ◯ **Decide together who knows**
  And agree on what each of you is comfortable sharing.
- ◯ **It's okay to skip a baby shower**
  Send a gift and a kind note. Protecting yourself isn't selfish.
- ◯ **Mute what hurts online**
  Pregnancy announcements can wait until you feel ready.
- ◯ **Have each other's backs**
  If a question upsets your partner, step in and change the subject.

# If it's taking *longer*

Many couples don't get pregnant in the first few months, and that's normal. If time goes on, the key is to face the next steps as a team, not as the one with the problem and the one who waits.

## When to see a doctor, based on her age

**Under 35**
after 12 months of trying

**35 to 39**
after 6 months of trying

**40 and over**
right away, when you start

- [ ] **Go to appointments together**
  And get tested at the same time. Fertility is a question for both of you.
- [ ] **Make decisions as a team**
  Treatments, budget, and breaks. Neither of you should carry them alone.
- [ ] **Drop the blame**
  Whatever the tests show, it's “our” challenge, not “your” fault.
- [ ] **Keep a life outside of trying**
  Friends, hobbies, and plans that have nothing to do with a baby.

## Signs it's time for a counselor

- Trying is all you talk about
- You argue more than you used to
- You avoid sex or each other
- One of you feels alone in it

Look for a couples therapist or a counselor who specializes in fertility. Many fertility clinics can recommend one.

PRINT ME

# Your couple's *checklist*

Everything on one page. Stick it somewhere you'll both see it.

## This week

- ◯ Read this guide together
- ◯ Pick a time for your weekly check-in
- ◯ Agree on your shared plan
- ◯ Choose three repair phrases each
- ◯ Agree on a break signal
- ◯ Pick two small rituals

## Every week

- ◯ Weekly check-in, 20–30 minutes
- ◯ One baby-free date night
- ◯ Intimacy outside the fertile window
- ◯ Say one thank-you a day

## Every cycle

- ◯ Plan test day together
- ◯ Plan something good for that day
- ◯ Make room for feelings after a negative test
- ◯ Check in on how you're each coping

## Every few months

- ◯ Revisit your shared plan
- ◯ Check your doctor timeline
- ◯ Ask: do we need extra support?
- ◯ Plan something to look forward to

## Our agreements

**Our check-in time** _____

**Our break signal** _____

**Our test-day plan** _____

**My three repair phrases** _____

**Your three repair phrases** _____

# Notes for your *check-ins*

## Keep going together

Keep tracking your cycle in the Mia app and explore more helpful information about getting ready for pregnancy. For your body's prep, see the **Start Strong** PDF guide, and for his side, the **Maximize Your Chances** PDF guide.

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This guide is for general education and isn't a substitute for professional counseling or medical advice. If you're struggling, please reach out to a qualified professional.